

On time vs In time (and At the end vs In the end)

CEFR B1

Lesson Pack · summary, worksheet & answer key

Quick answer

Two easily confused pairs of fixed phrases:

- 1 on time = punctual (The meeting started on time).
- 2 in time (for/to) = early enough, before it's too late (just in time).
- 3 at the end (of) = at the finishing point; in the end = finally, in conclusion.

'At the end' usually needs 'of' (at the end of the street). 'In the end' stands alone and means 'finally'.

At a glance

Phrase	Meaning	Example
on time	punctual, at the scheduled time	The train left on time .
in time (for/to)	early enough, not too late	We arrived in time for dinner.
at the end (of)	at the finishing point	at the end of the film
in the end	finally, after everything	In the end , we stayed home.

Learning objectives

- Can distinguish 'on time' (punctual) from 'in time' (early enough) (CEFR B1).
- Can use 'in time for/to'.
- Can distinguish 'at the end (of)' from 'in the end' (finally).

Practice worksheet

Circle the correct option. On time vs In time (and At the end vs In the end) · CEFR B1

Name: _____

Date: _____

1. The 9:00 train left exactly ____ .

- | | |
|------------|----------------|
| A. on time | B. in time |
| C. at time | D. in the time |

2. We ran to the platform and got there just ____ to catch it.

- | | |
|------------|------------|
| A. in time | B. on time |
| C. at time | D. by time |

3. Please be ____ for the meeting; it starts at ten sharp.

- | | |
|------------|----------------|
| A. on time | B. in time |
| C. at time | D. in the time |

4. There's a big surprise ____ of the film.

- | | |
|---------------|---------------|
| A. at the end | B. in the end |
| C. at end | D. on the end |

5. We looked at many houses and ____ we bought the first one.

- | | |
|---------------|---------------|
| A. in the end | B. at the end |
| C. on the end | D. at end |

6. I arrived ____ to say goodbye before she left.

- | | |
|------------|---------------|
| A. in time | B. on time |
| C. at time | D. in the end |

7. The bus is never ____ ; it's always five minutes late.

- | | |
|------------|----------------|
| A. on time | B. in time |
| C. at time | D. in the time |

8. ____ of the street, turn left.

- | | |
|---------------|---------------|
| A. At the end | B. In the end |
| C. On the end | D. At end |

9. Correct this: 'We got to the airport on time to catch the last flight.'

- | | |
|--|--|
| A. We got to the airport in time to catch the last flight. | B. We got to the airport on time to catch the last flight. |
| C. We got to the airport at time to catch the last flight. | D. The sentence is already correct. |

10. What does 'in time' mean?

- | | |
|--|-----------------------------------|
| A. Early enough, before it's too late. | B. Exactly at the scheduled time. |
| C. Finally, after everything. | D. At the finishing point. |

Answer key

Correct answers with explanations · for the teacher

1. **A. on time** — Punctual = 'on time'.
2. **A. in time** — Early enough, not too late = 'in time'.
3. **A. on time** — Punctual = 'on time'.
4. **A. at the end** — The finishing point takes 'at the end of'.
5. **A. in the end** — 'Finally' = 'in the end'.
6. **A. in time** — Early enough, before it was too late = 'in time'.
7. **A. on time** — Punctual = 'on time'.
8. **A. At the end** — A place/finishing point takes 'At the end of'.
9. **A. We got to the airport in time to catch the last flight.** — 'Early enough' = 'in time to catch it'.
10. **A. Early enough, before it's too late.** — 'In time' = early enough.